

EIGHTH EDITION

Keen's Latin American Civilization

History & Society, 1492 to the Present

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rapidly before him, still dancing, at his heart, which had been marked before-hand with a white mark. And in this way they made his whole chest one point like a hedgehog of arrows. If the heart of the victim was to be taken out, they led him with a great show and company of people of the temple, and having smeared him with blue and put on a *coroza*, they brought him up to the round altar, which was the place of sacrifice, and after the priest and his officials had anointed the stone with a blue color, and by purifying the temple drove out the evil spirit, the *Chacs* seized the poor victim, and placed him very quickly on his back upon that stone, and all four held him by the legs and arms, so that they divided him in the middle. At this came the executioner, the *Nacom*, with a knife of stone, and struck him with great skill and cruelty a blow between the ribs of his left side under the nipple, and he at once plunged his hand in there and seized the heart like a raging tiger and snatched it out alive and, having placed it upon a plate, he gave it to the priest, who went very quickly and anointed the faces of the idols with that fresh blood. Sometimes they made this sacrifice on the stone and high altar of the temple, and then they threw the body, now dead, rolling down the steps. The officials below took it and flayed it whole, taking off all the skin with the exception of the feet and hands, and the priest, all bare, covered himself, stripped naked as he was, with that skin, and the others danced with him. And this was considered as a thing of great solemnity amongst them. The custom was usually to bury in the court of the temple those whom they had sacrificed, or else they ate them, dividing him among those who had arrived (first) and the lords, and the hands, feet and head were reserved for the priest and his officials, and they considered those who were sacrificed as holy. If the victims were slaves captured in war, their master took their bones, to use them as a trophy in their dances as token of victory. Sometimes they threw living victims into the well of Chichen Itza, believing that they would come out on the third day, although they never appeared again.

9. MAYAN ORIGIN MYTH

Spanish efforts to eradicate Mayan religious practices resulted in the destruction of all but a few scattered hieroglyphic texts probably used by the Maya in divination. At the same time, European alphabetic writing—an integral part of the education of elite Native American children—provided new, if generally covert, ways to preserve traditional religious beliefs. Written down sometime during the mid-sixteenth century in Quiché (one of the principal Mayan languages) and intended to inform the councils of Quiché leaders, the Popol Vuh is a splendid example of the subversive appropriation of one of the principal weapons of conquest, written language—and it also provides a unique glimpse into Mayan religion. Unlike pre-conquest hieroglyphic texts, which required extensive expertise to interpret, the Popol Vuh integrated the divinatory as-

pects of Mayan religion into a compelling narrative that included mythical figures like the hero twins, Hunahpu and Xbalanque, whose adventures culminate in a heavenly ascent as part of a detailed account of the four stages of human creation. "Discovered" and preserved by a Spanish friar, Francisco Ximénez, the Popol Vuh continues to play a role in Quiché religious life. This selection tells the story of the successful fourth creation that followed three failed attempts to create humans from animals, mud, and wood. Munro Edmonson's translation highlights the mixture of ritual invocation and storytelling that characterize this hybrid creation myth.

*And this is the beginning when man was invented, / And when that which
would go into man's body was sought.
Then spoke the Bearer, / And Engenderer,
Who were Former / And Shaper, / Majesty / And Quetzal Serpent by name,
"The dawn has already appeared; / The creation has already been made,
And there is clearly a nourisher appearing, / A supporter,
Born of light, / Engendered of light.
Man has already appeared, / The population of the surface of the earth," they
said.*

*It was all assembled and came / And went, their wisdom,
In the darkness, / In the night time,
As they originated things, / And dissolved things.
They thought; / And they meditated there
And thus came their wisdom directly, bright / And clear.
They found / And they maintained / What came to be / Man's body.
That was just a little later / There not having appeared
The sun, / Moon / And stars / Over the heads
Of Former / And Shaper.*

*In Cleft, / In Bitter Water by name,
There came then yellow corn ears / And white corn ears.*

*And there are the names of the animals; / These were the bringers of the food:
Wildcat, / Coyote, / Parakeet / And Crow.
They are the four animals / Who told the news
Of the yellow corn ears / And white corn ears to them.
There they went then to Cleft / To point out the Cleft road,
And there they found the food / Whence came the flesh
Of the formed people, / The shaped people.*

The Book of Counsel. The Popol Vuh of the Quiche Maya of Guatemala, edited and translated by Munro S. Edmonson (New Orleans: Middle American Research Institute, Tulane University, 1971), pp. 145–155. Reprinted by permission of the Edmonson family.

And water was their blood; / It became man's blood.
 There came to Bearer / And Engenderer the corn ears.
 And they rejoiced then / Over the discovery
 Of the marvelous mountain, / Filled / With quantities / And quantities
 Of yellow corn ears, / And white corn ears,
 And also loads of cacao / And chocolate,
 Numberless maneyes, / Custard apples, / Anonas, / Nances, / Soursops / And
 honey.

It was full of the sweetest foods, / In the town
 At Cleft, / And at Bitter Water by name.
 There was food there / From the fruit of everything:
 Small vegetables, / Big vegetables, / Small plants / And big plants.
 The road was pointed out / By the animals.
 And the yellow corn was ground / And the white corn,
 And nine bushels / Were made by Xnuacane.
 The food came / With water to create strength,
 And it became man's grease / And turned into his fat
 When acted upon by Bearer / And Engenderer,
 Majesty / And Quetzal Serpent, as they are called.
 And so then they put into words the creation, / The shaping
 Of our first mother / And father.
 Only yellow corn / And white corn were their bodies.
 Only food were the legs / And arms of man.
 Those who were our first fathers / Were the four original men.
 Only food at the outset / Were their bodies.

These are the names of the first men who were made, / Who were shaped:
 The first was Jaguar Quiche, / And the second in turn was Jaguar Night,
 And the third in turn was Nought, / And the fourth was Wind Jaguar,
 And these are the names of our first mothers / And fathers.
 Only formed, / Only shaped they were said to be.
 They had no mother; / They had no father.
 Just heroes by themselves / We have said.
 No woman bore them; / Nor were they engendered
 By the Former / And Shaper, / The Bearer / And Engenderer.
 Just power, / Just magic
 Was their forming, / Their shaping
 By the Former / And Shaper.
 Bearer / And Engenderer, / Majesty / And Quetzal Serpent.
 And when they looked like men / They became men.
 They spoke / And they talked; / They saw / And they heard;
 They walked; / They grasped;
 They were fine men. / They were handsome. / Manly faces / Were their
 features.

They had breath / And existed.
 And they could see too; / Immediately their sight began.
 They came to see; / They came to know
 Everything under heaven / If they could see it.
 Suddenly they could look around / And see around
 In the sky, / In the earth.
 It was scarcely an instant / Before everything could be seen.
 They didn't have to walk at first / So as to gaze at what was under heaven:
 They were just there and looked. / Their understanding became great.
 Their gaze passed over trees, / Rocks, / Lakes, / Seas, / Mountains / And valleys.
 Truly then / They were the most beloved of men,
 Jaguar Quiche, / Jaguar Night, / Nought / And Wind Jaguar.

And then they were asked by the Former / And Shaper:
 "How pleasant is your existence? / Do you know? / Can't you see? / Can't you
 hear?"

Isn't your language good / And your walking?
 And look now / At what you see under heaven!
 Aren't the mountains clear? / Do you see the valleys?
 Then try it now! / They were told.
 And so then they came to see everything under heaven, / And so then they gave
 thanks.

To Former, / And Shaper,
 "Truly then twice thanks, / Thrice thanks that we are created already,
 And that we are mouthed / And faced.
 We can speak; / We can bear; / We ponder; / We move;
 We think very well; / We understand
 Far / And near,
 And we can see large / And small,
 What is in heaven, / What is on earth.
 Thanks then to you / That we are created, / We are formed, / We are shaped,
 We exist, oh our grandmother, / Oh our grandfather,"
 They said / As they gave thanks
 For their forming, / Their shaping.
 They came to understand everything; / They saw it:
 The four creations, / The four destructions
 The womb of heaven, / The womb of earth.
 And not very happily / Did they listen to this,
 The Former / And Shaper.
 "It is not good / What they said,
 Our forming, / Our shaping:
 We know everything great / And small," they said.
 And so they took back again / Their knowledge,

Did Bearer / And Engenderer.

"How shall we make them again / So that their sight reaches only nearby?

So that it will just be a little space / Of the surface of the earth that they see?

It is not good / What they say.

Aren't their names just formed / And shaped?

But quite like gods / Will they become then

Unless they begin to multiply / And begin to grow numerous

When it whitens, / When it brightens:

Unless it increases. / Then so be it!

Let's just undo them a little more. / That's what is still needed.

It isn't good what we have found out. / Won't they just equate their deeds with

ours

If their understanding reaches too far / And they see everything?" they were told

By the Heart of Heaven, / 1 Leg, / Dwarf Lightning, / Green Lightning,

Majesty, / Quetzal Serpent, / Bearer, / And Engenderer, / Xpiucoc, / Xmucane,

Former! And Shaper, as they are called.

And then they made / Their life over

For their forming, / Their shaping.

And their eyes were clipped / By the Heart of Heaven.

They were blinded like the clouding of the surface of a mirror; / Their eyes were

all blinded.

They could only see nearby then, / However clear things might be,

And thus they lost their understanding, / And all the wisdom of the four men

At the start, / At the beginning.

And thus was the forming, / The shaping

Of our grandfathers, / Our first fathers

By the Heart of Heaven, / The Heart of Earth.

And then there were their mates; / And their wives came to exist.

Only the gods / Invented them too.

Thus it was just in their sleep! That they brought them then.

Truly they were beautiful / And they were women

For Jaguar Quiche / Jaguar Night, / Nought / And Wind Jaguar.

When their wives were there they were properly brought to life / At once their

hearts rejoiced again over their mates.

And these are their names; / Their wives were these:

Red Sea House was the name / Of the wife of Jaguar Quiche;

Beauty House was the name / Of the wife of Jaguar Night;

Hummingbird House was the name / Of the wife of Nought;

Parrot House was the name / Of the wife Wind Jaguar.

And these were the names of their wives, / Who became queens.

They were the bearers of the little tribes, / The great tribes,

And this was the root of us / Who are Quiche people.

10. HOW THE INCA FORMED A NATION

The Inca made a systematic attempt to unify the institutions and even the language of their extensive empire; that they had considerable success in the latter is shown by the fact that five-sixths of the Indians of the Andean area still speak Quechua, the official language of the empire. The Inca obtained their results with the aid of an elaborate bureaucracy that brought every inhabitant of the empire under the direct and continuous control of an official appointed by the emperor. An important factor in the success of the Inca plan of unification was the policy of resettlement or colonization, described below by Father Cobo.

The entire empire of the Inca, though so extensive and composed of so many diverse nations, was a single commonwealth, ruled by the same laws, statutes, and customs and observing the same religion, rites, and ceremonies. . . .

The first thing that these kings did after conquering a province was to remove six or seven thousand families, more or less, as seemed best to them, taking into account the capacity and temper of the population, and to transfer these families to the quiet, peaceful provinces, assigning them to different towns. In their stead they introduced the same number of people, taken from the places to which the former families had been sent or from such other places as seemed convenient; among these people were many nobles of royal blood. Those who were thus domiciled in new lands were called *mitimaes*—that is, newcomers or strangers, as distinct from the natives. This term applied to the new vassals as well as to the old ones who were sent in their places, since both went from their own to foreign lands; even today we use the word in this sense, calling *mitimaes* all those newcomers who have settled

Bernabé Cobo, *Historia del Nuevo Mundo*, 4 vols. (Seville, 1890–1893), vol. 3, pp. 222–225. Excerpt translated by Benjamin Keen.

in the provinces of this kingdom. In these transfers of population they saw to it that the migrants, both the newly conquered persons and the others, were moved to lands whose climate and conditions were the same as, or similar to, those which they had left behind and in which they had been reared. . . .

The Incas introduced these changes of domicile in order to maintain their rule with greater ease, quiet, and security; for since the city of Cuzco, their capital, where they had their court and residence, was so distant from the provinces most lately acquired, in which there were many barbarous and warlike nations, they considered that there was no other way to keep them in peaceful submission. And since this was the principal purpose of the transfer, they ordered the majority of the *mitimases* whom they sent to the recently conquered towns to make their homes in the provincial capitals, where they served as garrisons, not for wages or for a limited time but in perpetuity, both they and their descendants. As soldiers they received certain privileges to make them appear of nobler rank, and they were ordered always to obey the slightest commands of their captains and governors. Under this plan, if the natives revolted, the *mitimases*, being devoted to the governors, soon reduced them to obedience to the Inca; and if the *mitimases* rioted they were repressed and punished by the natives; thus, through this scheme of domiciling the majority of the people of some province in other parts, the king was made secure against revolts in his dominions, and the social and commercial intercourse among the different provinces was more frequent and the entire land was better supplied with all its needs.

The Inca profited further by this transfer of their vassals from one part to another in that throughout the length and breadth of the Empire similarity and conformity prevailed in religion and government. All the nations learned and spoke the language of Cuzco, which thus came to be general throughout Peru; for through this change of domicile the newly conquered peoples, removed into the interior of the kingdom, learned all this quickly and without difficulty or coercion, and the old vassals who were resettled in place of the new subjects who were being pacified taught it to the natives. The Inca required everyone to absorb their language, laws, and religion, with all the beliefs about these matters that were established at Cuzco; they either partly or wholly abolished their former usages and rites and made them receive their own. In order to introduce and establish these things more effectively, in addition to transferring people they would remove the principal idol from a conquered province and set it up in Cuzco with the same attendance and worship that it had formerly had; all this was seen to by persons who had come from that province, just as they had done when they had had the idol in their own country. For this reason Indians from every province of the kingdom were at all times in residence in the capital and court, occupied in guarding and ministering to their own idols. Thus they learned the usages and customs of the court; and when they were replaced by others according to their system of *mitas*, or turns, on their return to their own country they taught their people what they had seen and learned in the court.

11. THE VILLAGE BASIS OF INCAN SOCIETY

The basic unit of Incan social organization was the ayllu, a kinship group whose members claimed descent from a common ancestor. An Inca village typically consisted of several ayllus. The chronicler Garcilaso de la Vega (1539-1616), son of a Spanish noble and an Incan princess, drew an idyllic picture of Indian village life and of the relations between the Inca and their subjects. His account of a happy peasantry going forth with songs and rejoicing to labor in the service of their king is at serious variance with what is known of the chronic unrest and frequent revolts of conquered tribes against their Incan rulers.

In the matter of working and cultivating the fields they also established good order and harmony. First they worked the fields of the sun, then those of the widows and orphans and of those disabled by old age or illness: all such were regarded as poor people, and therefore the Inca ordered that their lands should be cultivated for them. In each town, or in each ward if the town was large, there were men assigned exclusively to look after the cultivation of the fields of the persons that we would call poor. These deputies were called *llac-tamayus*, or town councillors. It was their task, at the time of plowing, sowing, and harvesting the fields, to ascend at night towers that were made for this purpose, to blow on a trumpet or shell to attract attention, and loudly announce: "On such-and-such a day the fields of the disabled persons will be cultivated; let each betake himself to his assigned place." The people in each precinct already knew, by means of a list that had been made, to which fields they must go; these were the fields of their relatives or closest neighbors. Each one had to bring his own food, whatever he had in the house, so that the disabled persons would not have to provide for them. For they said that the aged, the sick, and the widows and orphans had trouble enough of their own, without being burdened with the troubles of others. If the disabled persons had no seeds they were provided from the storehouses, of which we shall have more to say hereafter. The fields of the soldiers who were away at war were also worked in common, for when their husbands were absent on army duty the wives were counted as widows. And so they performed this favor for them as for needy people. They took great care in the rearing of the children of those who were killed in the wars, until such time as they were married.

After the fields of the poor had been cultivated, each one tilled his own, and they helped each other in groups, cultivating their fields in turn. Then they tilled the fields of the *curaca*, the chief, and these were the last to be worked in each town or province. In the time of Huaina Capac, in a town of

Garcilaso de la Vega, *Comentarios reales de los Incas*, 2 vols. (Buenos Aires, 1943), vol. 1, pp. 227-229. Excerpt translated by Benjamin Keen.